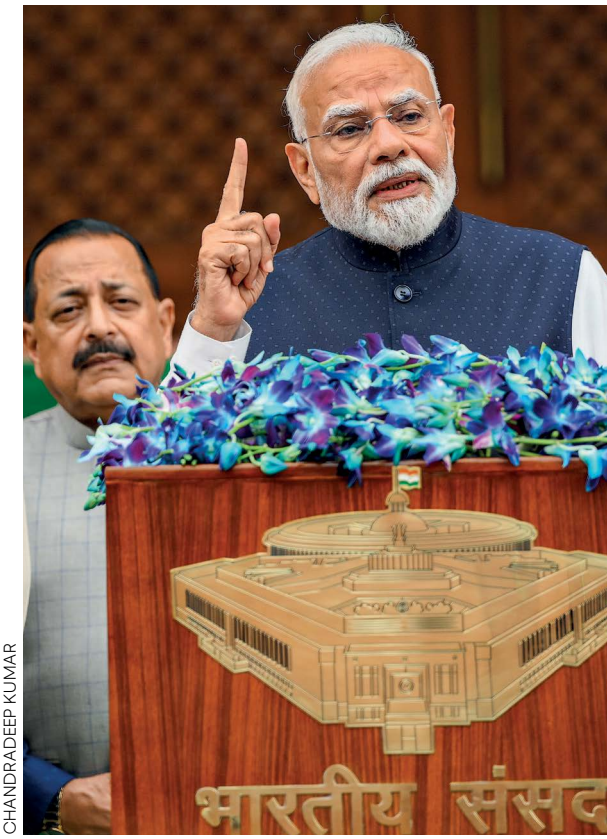
POWERS THAT BE Clockwise from below, PM Modi addressing media on Day 1 of monsoon session; education minister Dharmendra Pradhan; Rahul Gandhi being detained during his sit-in



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR





and Jat farmers in one case, Muslim protesters and their allies in the other, communities a government could court, isolate or wait out. The CJP crowd resists that kind of easy classification. It includes students from elite universities and provincial colleges, English-speaking professionals and lower-middle-class aspirants, young women, parents and first-time protesters drawn from Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, Punjab, Uttarakhand and beyond. There is no caste, region or religion here for the government to set against one another; there is only its own most reliable constituency, asking to be heard.

The scale and shape of the anger invite comparison with youth-led uprisings elsewhere in South Asia—Sri Lanka in 2022, Bangladesh in 2024 and Nepal last year. The parallels are easy to draw: a large young population, high unemployment, leaderless mobilisation, the central role of social media, and a surge sudden enough to catch the political establishment off guard. A closer domestic parallel is Anna Hazare's 2011-12 India Against Corruption movement. Both acquired an ostensibly non-party character, occupied public space in the capital and converted a specific grievance into a wider indictment of the government of the day.

That history is exactly why the CJP unsettles the principal Opposition party almost as much as it does the BJP. The Congress remembers how the anti-corruption movement weakened the United Progressive Alliance (UPA) but ultimately gave birth to the Aam Aadmi Party, which went on to occupy much of its political space in Delhi. A successful, independent youth platform could damage the Congress as much as it dents the BJP—which explains the party's almost rueful ambivalence, and its scramble to reclaim the agitational space, where its own sporadic efforts never gain such traction.

Realising that it was better off joining ranks with the CJP, Congress leaders Rahul Gandhi, Priyanka Gandhi Vadra and Mallikarjun Kharge, along with Akhilesh Yadav of the Samajwadi Party, staged a surprise, unpermitted sit-in outside 7, Lok Kalyan Marg, on July 21. No Leader of the Opposition had previously protested outside a prime minister's residence; the last comparable sit-in there was held in 1999, by the families of the IC-814 hostages. What followed handed the Congress the images it wanted. Rahul was seen lying on the road as the police tried to lift him and was then carried away, his nose bloodied. "Democracy in India is happening right now," he said as he was being taken away. The moment did what two months of protest at Jantar Mantar had not quite managed: it shifted the target of the agitation from administrative failure to Modi personally.

THE TASK BEFORE MODI SARKAR

This agitation comes 12 years into Modi's rule, driven by voters who have known no other government. A first-time voter in 2026 was six years old when Modi took office; much of this generation has no political memory of the UPA at all. The BJP can no longer explain institutional failure simply invoking the disorder of an earlier government. For 12 years, Modi has presented himself as the one force capable of fixing a broken system. The protesters gathered under the CJP's banner are now asking: what if they see him not as the system's reformer, but as a custodian, of the status quo? Amidst the Gen Z standoff at Jantar Mantar, Modi on X said his government had decided to set up fast-track courts to ensure swift and stringent punishment